SPOTLIGHT
Badshah (centre), the judge, with other contestants in *MTV Hustle 2.0*; (below) Srushti Tawade

platform." Joshua, however, remains unsure of whether the recognition that the *MTV Hustle* participants received from Indian audiences—including celebrities like Virat Kohli and Anushka Sharma—would translate into a long and successful career. Rapper KR$NA, too, remains convinced that for anyone looking to make a name as a rapper, there can be no substitute for the "real hustle". He says, "I think reality shows can be a good platform for artists looking for a push, but I don't think reality shows are a sure-shot way to 'make it' in the industry."

In a country burdened by umpteen singing reality show competitions that often commodify new talent under the guise of discovering them, *MTV Hustle 2.0* doesn't exactly occupy a unique position. Like several other shows, it offers a templatised understanding of hip-hop, so that it can turn the genre into bite-sized entertainment. Much of the doubt over whether the show can traverse the distance between upcoming rappers and a dedicated audience also stems from the very purpose of hip-hop as an art form. KR$NA, for instance, says, "As someone who has dedicated their life to the art form, I feel that authenticity comes from the real-life grind. Any artist can only really break through in the scene if they have put in the work and connected with their own audience. Reality shows are better suited to make pop stars than rap stars, and I think [even after this season] that's quite evident." ■

Poulomi Das

Striking a Chord

Much like Amit Trivedi's film scores, the music composer's new EP also takes its cues from the heart

There's an endearing nervous energy to Amit Trivedi as he takes the stage at the Spotify office in Mumbai. His audience comprises a small crowd of journalists, influencers and AT superfans. Trivedi is here for the launch of his new EP *Jadu Salona*, which has just been released by his label AT Azaad, in collaboration with digital music company Believe. The composer, singer and lyricist–known for his outstanding work on the soundtracks of *Dev.D* (2009), *Udta Punjab* (2016) and *Manmarziyaan* (2018)–spends half an hour performing some songs and weaving all six tracks into an elaborate, *filmy* love story. "*Mujhe ishq se mohabbat hai* (I'm in love with love)," he declares at one point.

So why, after a decade of consistent success with Bollywood, does Trivedi want to entertain the risks and uncertainty of a non-film independent release? "I always wanted to go independent, always," he says when we sit down for a chat after the EP launch. "But films happened, and I was too busy to even think about my original passion. And then, one day, I had to put my foot down and make time to pursue this very old dream."

Trivedi dipped his toes into the space with the launch of AT Azaad in 2020, a label where he could put out music without any restrictions or compromises. He has already put out a few collections of tracks on the label, simply titled *Songs of Faith*, *Songs of Love* and *Songs of Trance*, but *Jadu Salona* is its first proper release. The six tracks here don't stray too far from the classic Amit Trivedi sound–contemporary electro-pop with subtle, sophisticated melodies and, yes, a *filmy* twist–but Trivedi makes good use of his freedom to experiment with more off-trend ideas on tracks like 'Nirmohi' and 'Rahiyo Na'.

"Love was the thematic starting point for the EP, and the story arc just emerged once the songs were written," he says. When I ask whether a romance-focused album is all that much of a departure from film music, he scoffs. "Love stories and rom-coms, really good ones, have become such a rarity [in Bollywood] these days. And I love that genre. *Par karta hi nahin koi* (but nobody does it)."

Trivedi plans to lock himself in a studio in Goa for a month and create a second edition of *Songs of Trance*



One Bollywood love story he has been able to work on is Anurag Kashyap's *Almost Pyaar with DJ Mohabbat*, and Trivedi is excited to team up again with one of his favourite collaborators. But what really gets him going are his plans for future moves in the independent space. He plans to lock himself in a studio in Goa for a month and create a second edition of *Songs of Trance*, and then put together a tour where he performs only his independently released music. He also eventually wants to sign more artists onto AT Azaad, offering them the freedoms he's enjoying himself.

This doesn't mean a divorce from Bollywood. As the composer points out, he feels eternally grateful for the opportunities that the film industry has given him. "*Pyaar bahut karta hun Bollywood se* (I love Bollywood a lot)," he declares. "*Par dil se indie hun* (but I'm indie at heart)." ■

Bhanuj Kappal